



ENTRY PRINCIPLE

Earn the right to simplify.

A new Chief of Staff should not begin by imposing meetings, dashboards, or templates. The first responsibility is to understand the existing operating system, the trust network around the CEO, and the few places where greater traceability would materially improve decisions and outcomes.

120-day objective

Build a trusted, decision-focused operating mechanism that increases CEO leverage, strengthens executive ownership, and improves progress on the company's highest-value cross-functional priorities.

OPERATING GUARDRAILS

Do

- Use existing information before creating new reporting
- Preserve functional ownership and expert authority
- Focus executive forums on decisions and exceptions
- Label hypotheses and test them through discovery
- Retire mechanisms that do not improve outcomes

Do not

- Become the default owner of every cross-functional task
- Create a shadow project-management organization
- Confuse activity visibility with business progress
- Escalate issues that can be resolved locally
- turn confidentiality into opacity or status theater

YEAR-ONE SCORECARD CATEGORIES

FOCUS

Executive attention allocated to the right priorities

VELOCITY

Decisions and constraints resolved faster

OWNERSHIP

Clearer accountability and closure

TRUST

Reliable information and discreet follow-through

ADOPTION

Operating rhythms used because they help

LEARNING

Fewer repeated failure patterns

Days 0-30: Read the operating system

LISTEN, MAP, AND EARN TRUST

Russell Dudek

<https://russelldudek.github.io/Metr/>

0-30

Understand how strategy, decisions, ownership, information, and relationships actually move before changing the cadence.

DISCOVERY WORKSTREAMS

WORKSTREAM	QUESTIONS	EVIDENCE
CEO leverage	What requires the CEO? What could be delegated, clarified, or stopped?	Calendar patterns, decision backlog, recurring escalations.
Strategic portfolio	Which initiatives define the year? What outcomes and tradeoffs are explicit?	Strategy, board materials, operating plans, initiative records.
Executive rhythms	Which meetings produce decisions, learning, or accountability?	Agendas, pre-reads, actions, closure rates, recurring topics.
Cross-functional flow	Where do product, technology, markets, support, growth, finance, legal, and people work depend on one another?	Handoffs, queues, exceptions, unresolved dependencies.
Trust network	Who holds critical context? Where is candor high or low?	Stakeholder interviews and observed working relationships.

STAKEHOLDER LISTENING MAP

Executive and governance

CEO, CVO / board chair, CFO, CTO, CMO, growth, external affairs / business development, customer experience, HR, legal, and board-facing partners.

Operating and technical

Product, engineering, implementation, support, training, market operations, data, security, finance, and people leaders.

External interfaces

Government customers, operators, integrators, strategic partners, and selected market stakeholders where appropriate.

Frontline signal

People closest to user friction, market cutovers, support load, product adoption, data quality, and implementation reality.

Day-30 deliverables

1) Operating-rhythm map. 2) Strategic priority inventory. 3) Decision-latency and escalation map. 4) Stakeholder / trust topology. 5) Recommendations for two pilot priority traces. No broad redesign yet.

31-60

Pilot the Executive Priority Trace on two high-value cross-functional priorities using existing owners and information sources.

PILOT SELECTION CRITERIA

STRATEGIC VALUE

Material to company direction

CROSS-FUNCTIONAL LOAD

Multiple real dependencies

DECISION FRICTION

Meaningful unresolved tradeoff

Potential public-signal categories include platform modernization, a market implementation, Retail ID expansion, or a strategic partnership. Actual pilots would be selected with the CEO and ELT based on confidential priorities.

PILOT OPERATING STEPS

STEP	ACTION	GUARDRAIL
Tag	Define the outcome and why it matters now.	No activity-only objective.
Link	Name executive and operating owners.	Chief of Staff does not absorb ownership.
Map	Expose minimum dependencies and assumptions.	Do not map every task.
Decide	Define authority, thresholds, and next decision.	No ambiguous escalation.
Verify	Connect progress to evidence and adoption.	No unsupported percentage theater.
Close	Record result, residual risk, and learning.	Completed work leaves the agenda.

61-90

Tighten the CEO and ELT operating rhythm based on evidence from the pilots.

CADENCE CHANGES TO TEST

- Shift weekly reviews toward exceptions, decisions, and ownership.
- Consolidate duplicate status reporting into one portfolio trace.
- Introduce pre-read standards proportional to the decision.
- Clarify which forum owns which class of decision.
- Establish decision receipts and explicit follow-through.
- Retire meetings or reports that do not change action.

Day-90 deliverables

Two validated priority traces, CEO / ELT cadence charter, strategic portfolio view, decision-threshold taxonomy, reporting-retirement list, and a draft year-one Chief of Staff scorecard.

Days 91-120: Transfer and compound

INSTITUTIONALIZE OWNERSHIP AND LEARNING

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<https://russelldudek.github.io/Metric/>

91-120

Expand only what has demonstrated value, place the mechanism with the people who own the work, and make learning reusable.

INSTITUTIONALIZATION PRIORITIES

PRIORITY	ACTION	EVIDENCE OF ADOPTION
Ownership	Train executive and operating owners to maintain concise trace records.	Records stay current without Chief of Staff chasing every field.
Decision discipline	Standardize thresholds, pre-reads, and decision receipts.	Fewer revisited decisions and ambiguous actions.
Portfolio focus	Use quarterly reset to concentrate or retire priorities.	Capacity aligns to explicit strategy.
Learning	Create a registry of recurring constraints and reusable responses.	Repeated issues are recognized earlier.
Executive leverage	Delegate information flow and preserve CEO time for judgment.	Calendar and attention shift toward highest-value work.

YEAR-ONE OPERATING ROADMAP

Quarter 2 Extend trace discipline to the strategic portfolio; strengthen executive review quality; establish board-facing synthesis where appropriate.	Quarter 4 Review the Chief of Staff mechanism itself: what improved decisions, what became overhead, and what should be transferred, automated, or stopped.
Quarter 3 Use cross-market, product, and customer learning to improve prioritization and operating consistency.	Year-end Present evidence of focus, decision velocity, ownership, trust, adoption, and learning - not a list of meetings managed.

EXECUTIVE RISK REGISTER

RISK	EARLY SIGNAL	RESPONSE
Role becomes central bottleneck	Owners wait for Chief of Staff action.	Return authority and make boundaries explicit.
Mechanism becomes reporting burden	Fields grow while decisions do not improve.	Reduce to minimum decision-useful record.
Executive forums drift to status	Updates consume agenda; decisions defer.	Exception-only pre-read and named decision maker.
Confidentiality reduces transparency	Teams cannot understand why priorities change.	Separate sensitive content from clear operating direction.

Day-120 outcome

A trusted Chief of Staff operating model that is useful enough to be adopted, light enough to sustain, explicit enough to improve accountability, and humble enough to be changed when the evidence says it should.